Pre & Post Donation Nutrition Plan

Plasma Pay Calculator — plasmapaycalculator.com

24 Hours Before Donating

- **Drink 80+ oz of water** — hydration is the #1 factor for fast donations
- **Eat 60-80g protein** — chicken, eggs, fish, beans, or protein shake
- **Iron-rich dinner:** Red meat or spinach + vitamin C (helps iron absorption)
- **Avoid:** Alcohol, fatty foods, excessive caffeine, high-sodium meals
- **Avoid:** NSAIDs (ibuprofen, aspirin) — can affect platelet function

Morning of Donation

- **16-20 oz water** first thing when you wake up
- **High-protein breakfast:** Eggs + toast, oatmeal + peanut butter, Greek yogurt
- **Iron supplement** with vitamin C (orange juice) if you tend to have low levels
- **Light cardio** (10-min walk) to get blood flowing
- **Another 16 oz water** 30 minutes before your appointment

Post-Donation Recovery

- **Drink 32+ oz water** in the first 2 hours after donating
- **Eat within 30 minutes:** Protein bar, sandwich, or the center's free snacks
- **Recovery meal:** Chicken, rice, vegetables — balanced protein + carbs
- **Rest:** No heavy lifting or intense exercise for 4-6 hours
- **Take iron supplement** with dinner (vitamin C helps absorption)

Weekly Meal Prep Template (Donation Days)

Meal	Option A	Option B	Option C
Breakfast	3 eggs + toast + OJ	Greek yogurt + granola + berries	Oatmeal + PB + banana

Pre-Donation Snack	Protein bar + water	Trail mix + water	Apple + PB + water
Post-Donation	Chicken sandwich	Turkey wrap + fruit	Protein shake + crackers
Dinner	Steak + spinach + rice	Salmon + broccoli + quinoa	Bean chili + cornbread

Top Iron-Rich Foods

Food	Iron (mg per serving)	Tips
Beef liver (3 oz)	5.2 mg	Highest iron food
Ground beef (3 oz)	2.2 mg	Easy to meal prep
Spinach (1 cup cooked)	6.4 mg	Pair with vitamin C
Fortified cereal	18 mg	Easy breakfast option
Lentils (1 cup)	6.6 mg	Great for vegetarians
Kidney beans (1 cup)	3.9 mg	Add to chili or salads
Dark chocolate (1 oz)	3.4 mg	Healthy snack option

Pro Tip: The #1 reason donors get deferred is low hematocrit/iron levels. Consistent hydration and iron-rich meals prevent 90% of deferrals.